reform and modernize, if it did not unite and maintain a strong central authority.

These negative attitudes persist, surfacing whenever relations start to worsen. During more positive phases, these attitudes are masked and the rhetoric harks back to the ancient period of civilizational engagement between the two countries, though even in this case the spread of Buddhism in China from India is regarded by some as a baneful external influence which should be thoroughly exorcised to allow the true Chinese spirit to emerge. While there are positive strains of thinking about India, particularly among those who have had more sustained encounters with its people, they do not constitute the dominant category.

In dealing with the China challenge, India needs to analyse these deeper strands in Chinese perceptions of India and the prism through which the Chinese mind interprets Indian foreign policy behaviour. These perceptions are mediated through third-party sources and not through direct Chinese experience of India and Indians over an extended period of time. Indian perceptions of China are also coloured by images and imaginings purveyed by others, mainly the English language discourse on China. This is a discourse which has at times romanticized the China story and at times disparaged it.

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Currently, we find that China is increasingly assessing India through the prism of its fraught and worsening relations with the US. India is not regarded as having independent agency. For the Chinese pessimist, the future could relive the past, in which India became the platform for an assault on China and hence needs to be neutralized well in time. India's people and leaders cannot be trusted because they are by nature (and not by calculation) given to petty intrigues and trickery. Sometimes, as we have seen, history may be rewritten or reinterpreted to fit preconceived notions about an adversary's character.

This points to the need for more intensive China studies in our country, in particular of its history, its culture, its society, and of the patterns of thought